its social base, primarily to Other Backward Classes (OBCs) and to a lesser extent to Scheduled Castes (SCs), and, finally, its approach to the Hindu–Muslim question.

The heart of its findings—how the BJP radically changed its positioning on caste after 2014 by giving a far greater space at all levels to those lower down the caste order than any other party in UP—comes from the Mehta–Singh Social Index, another original database that I created with my colleague, the journalist Sanjeev Singh. We studied the caste background of 4,415 political leaders in UP spread across three decades and four parties (BJP, Samajwadi Party [SP], Congress and Bahujan Samaj Party [BSP]). This included the caste backgrounds of all 2,560 Lok Sabha candidates fielded by these four parties in UP between 1991 and 2019; all 1,612 assembly election candidates fielded by the four parties in 2017; all 104 UP government ministers appointed between 2016 and 2019 (stretching across Akhilesh Yadav's SP and Yogi Adityanath's BJP governments); all forty-one state-level BJP office-bearers in UP and all ninety-eight district-level BJP presidents in 2020. The findings—which were rechecked multiple times—entailed a massive district-level investigation in each of UP's seventy-five districts.

Our checks included a process of blind review by separate teams working simultaneously on the same investigation to compare results, followed by a qualitative checking of lists with a cross-section of long-time Hindi journalists, academics and district-level politicians in the state, followed by random qualitative checks on specific regions with a cross-section of senior UP politicians across party lines. Despite being political junkies and having reported on the state for years, our findings on caste representation in the Mehta–Singh Index stunned us.

Part II delineates the BJP's tools of growth and political expansion. The Narad Index provides new insights into how the party calibrated its political messaging across time. A separate chapter examines how the BJP used social media and digital reach as a mass force multiplier in a country that underwent a mobile data revolution after 2015, and where digital is increasingly relevant. It takes a close look at how the party uses communication technologies and digital tools for political mobilisation, how funding